

04 May, 2003

Dear Jen,

I got another letter from you today; the one with Mason and the Easter bunny. What a great picture! He looks like he is getting so big so fast. I hate to miss all these stages. At least I get the pictures. They really make my day. I also got a letter from Lynn today. I will write her back tonight too. What a surprise, Fritz is debating whether or not to join the Peace Corps now. Why am I not surprised. I think that he would probably be happy just partying at the Rock Bottom. What do you think? It also comes to no surprise to me (and probably not to you either) that Fritz told Lynn that he wants to move out of the 'rents house. That seems to be a common feeling when you're stuck there doesn't it? Nothing against my parents but they can be tough to live with. Hey, it's a much better place to visit.

We "jumped TOC" again yesterday. We moved from the SCANIA dealership that has been our home for nearly three weeks to an Iraqi Airborne base. It was kind of sad to leave. We had gotten know all of the workers there pretty well. They had a good thing going too. We kept the looters away with our mere presence, and they were able to make a few dollars by selling us cigarettes, soda, and some cooked food from the market. It was a very symbiotic relationship. The 82nd Airborne relieved us there, and I hear that they have kicked out all the SCANIA workers that we had become friends with. Its sad to hear that.

Our new facility looks like it was under construction when the war began and was never finished. There is no landscaping, but that is really no surprise in Iraq where most of the ground seems to be dirt. The building, however, did not have light fixtures or toilets but did have piping. Its hard to tell whether the unfinished nature of this place is because the buildings were never completed or a result of the prominent looting that has been going on in Baghdad. One advantage for us, however, is the large size of the complex. We can easily fit all of our 44 tanks, our support and repair facilities in here. There is a lot of office and sleeping space as well. There are two identical main buildings inside the complex. They look like low-budget versions of my basic training facility at Ft. Sill, and they have what seems to be an Iraqi Airborne insignia painted over the main entrance to each. The two buildings are set parallel to each other, and the buildings themselves are mirror images of one another. In good military tradition, all the rooms are equal and look like they were used as barracks. The buildings are two stories tall and have a central corridor that is not really "inside" the building, just covered by the roof. At either end of this corridor is a bathroom. The dorm rooms jettison off on both sides of the corridor, and it is easy to imagine military training here. I can almost relive basic training and OCS by just looking at the facility.

The surrounding area is mainly dirt. There is a large wall surrounding the complex which provides us good security except for one spot where there is a hole. When we first got here children from the surrounding neighborhood came running up and peering through